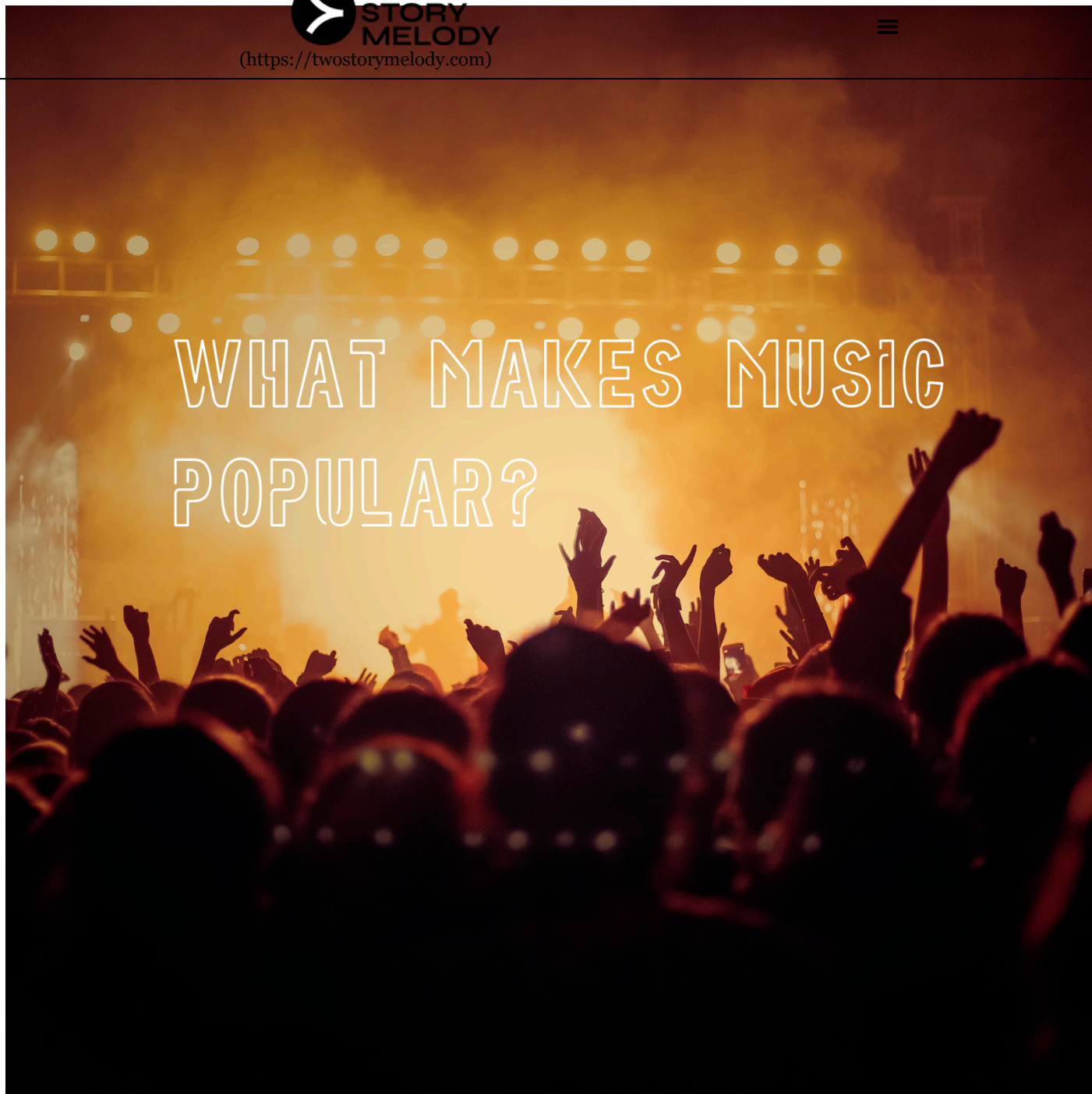

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WHAT MAKES MUSIC POPULAR?

By: Jon Anderson(<https://twostorymelody.com/author/admin/>) | February 5, 2024 | 6:31 pm



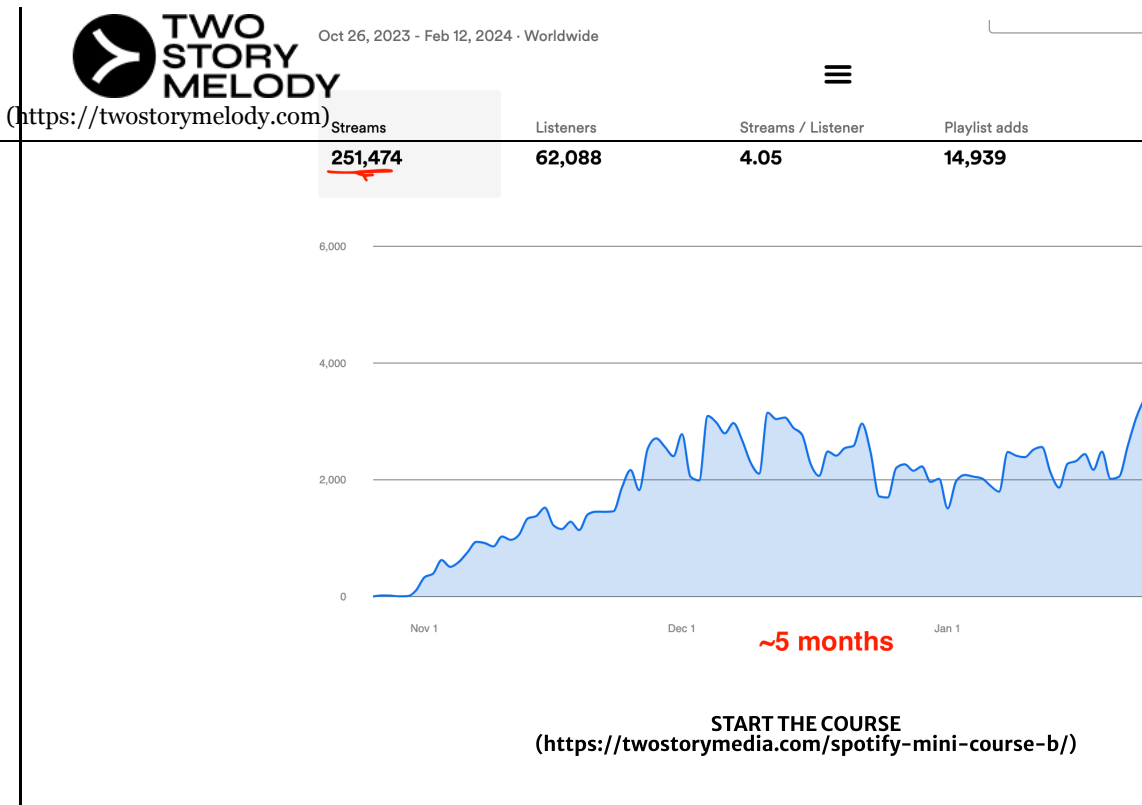
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It's a good question. It's a hard question. It's also the premise of Derek Thompson's *Hit Makers* (<https://Popularity-Distraction/dp/110198032X>), which I just finished yesterday while sitting at Starbucks.

(Yes, I finally got away from Panera. I think we can all agree that it was time.)

I don't typically rate books, because I don't believe that the quality of art can be strictly quantified... but if y
It's not a classic, for sure, but it's interesting enough that I'm still thinking about the ideas a day later.

I've found that the best way to unstick things from my head is to write them down – so with that said, here i
(<https://www.theatlantic.com/author/derek-thompson/>) about popularity that I've been chewing on.

1. We like familiar things.

One of the book's recurring themes is that people prefer what they know. It's a common-sense insight, but t
what they *don't* know) makes hit-making pretty hard, especially for people like you and I.

Let's assume, for a second, that you aren't Drake or Taylor Swift; instead, assume that you're an artist who i
that you and Taylor Swift (<https://twostorymelody.com/taylor-swift-all-too-well-and-the-importance-of-t>
identical in content, catchiness, and quality... and let's even go one step further and say that you both have i
and similar marketing budgets. (We can dream, right?)

The above scenario sounds pretty good, but here's the punchline: Even if your music and marketing were ec
(<https://twostorymelody.com/how-and-how-not-to-build-your-brand/>)s song would be far more likely to b
know Taylor Swift.

Familiarity is the foundation of hit-making.



That's true in every arena (the vast majority of box-office smashes are based on well-known stories or sequels) (https://twostorymelody.com)
vast majority of charting songs are released by artists who have already charted. Something like 90% of the time they pick something they've heard before.

Assuming that you aren't Taylor Swift, all of this means that getting your music heard is an uphill battle.

So, how do new hits break through?

The Myth of Overnight Success for Musicians | Andrew Southworth Interview



Maybe more to the point – how do relatively unknown indie artists get the attention of people who are prone to buying music?

Thompson's book doesn't answer this in straight lines, but it does suggest a few solutions.

That brings me to idea number two:

2. Consistency creates familiarity.

I'm a walking case study for this.

It may surprise you, but I am not, generally speaking, very well known. In fact, most people in the world do not know my name. The first time I order a drink at Starbucks and they spell my name wrong.

(It's Jon, not John – and yes, that letter does make a huge difference to my self-concept, but no, I can't bring it up because I don't want to be a Karen. On a related note, my mom's name is Karen, and she is a saintly woman)

But despite the fact that almost nobody in the world knows me, somewhere around 10,000 people read the least bit of it, at least sometimes – even though, in the scheme of things, I ~~am~~ basically a nobody.

(<https://twostorymelody.com>)

Why? Why do a bunch of people read me?

There are nuanced answers, of course, but probably the simplest reason is this: People read me because the

The data bears that out (to a ridiculous extent). Something like 95% of my readers have been on my email list if you had read something I'd written before you opened read this post.

I've been writing blog posts since 2015 and weekly newsletters (<https://twostorymedia.com/>) since around 2010. I'm probably familiar to the mass market, I'm probably familiar to you.

And that's why you're reading these words.

I haven't had the means to become familiar to a ton of people at once – I'm still waiting for Harry Styles (but we can make that happen – but by being consistent, I've become familiar to a small, but growing, number of people).

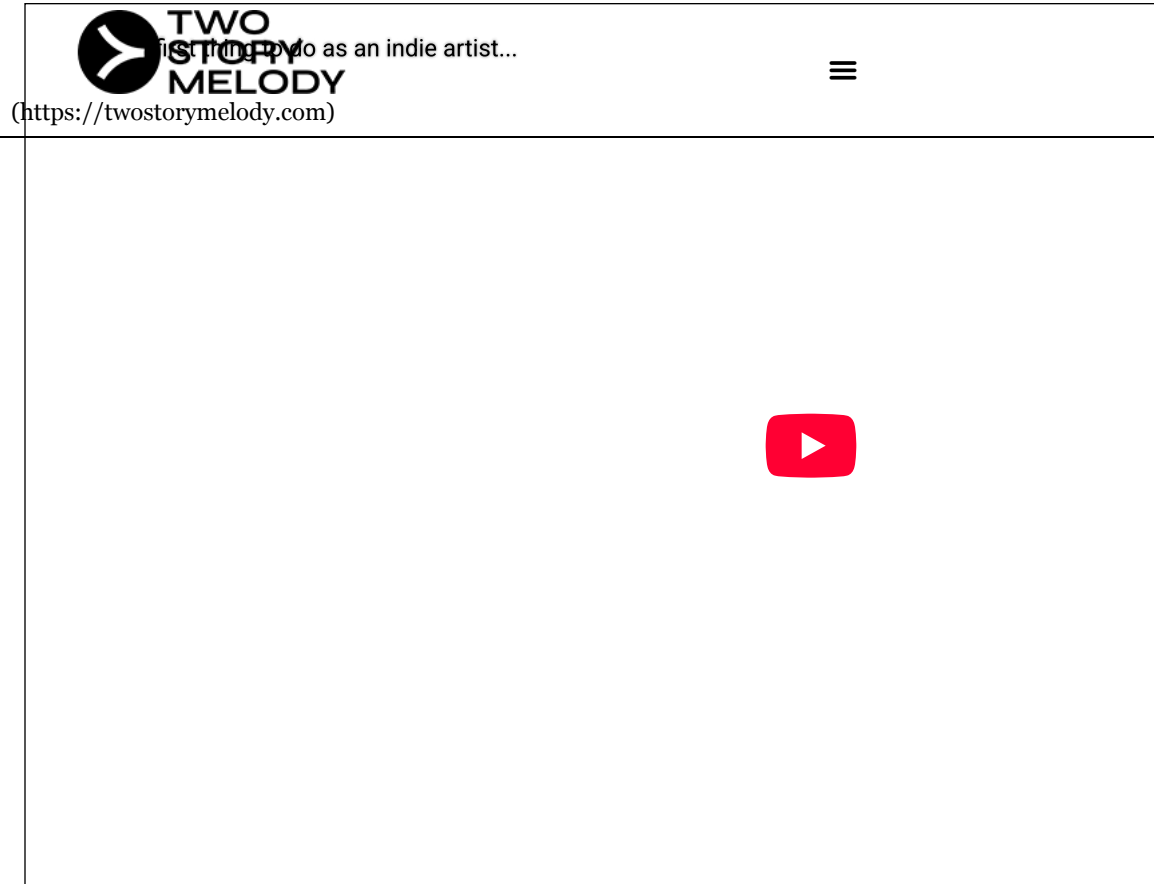
The same principle applies to music, which is why it's so important to keep creating consistently if you want to stand out in a market dominated by Taylor Swifts (https://www.yahoo.com/entertainment/grammys-2024-list-of-winners-0045guccounter=1&guce_referrer=aHRocHM6Ly93d3cuZ29vZ2xlLmNvbS8&guce_referrer_sig=AQAAAgoEiNO6N188SeIDtQ_HOoIi-EQRZLUaAHnTm9Fg-qIwmZDK1anWXEws1-ide_M16bMPaA7Et7rKCo_it1Pe4PZ9St1mcjIefhANwmS5zkHBmqtpWYQWBZaQ4), making music consistent to listen to you.

But it's not your only chance.

3. Context can be a trojan horse.

If people are averse to what's unfamiliar, then how do you get them to engage with new things at all? The solution is to wrap new things in familiar packaging.

You wrap new things in familiar packaging.



This is why genre references are so helpful (i.e., “Olivia Rodrigo is this generation’s Taylor Swift”). It’s why role in breaking music (i.e., “I heard that song on *Stranger Things*”). It’s why upcoming artists look for collab with TikTok stars have influence.

If you don’t have familiarity, you can associate yourself with things that do – and as you do so, some of it will

Sub-point here that’s loosely related: According to Thompson (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=l9KW3>), “virality” online. Virality is conceptualized as a series of rapid 1:1 transmissions – like giving one other person Covid, etc. Instead, “viral” ideas almost always benefit from a big broadcast; rather than going from one person super-spread to tons of people at once through big platforms.

In other words, you won’t make something popular by getting ten people to tell ten people; you’ll make something to tweet about it.

The takeaway for indie artists: Look for things your ideal listener is already familiar with, then look for ways

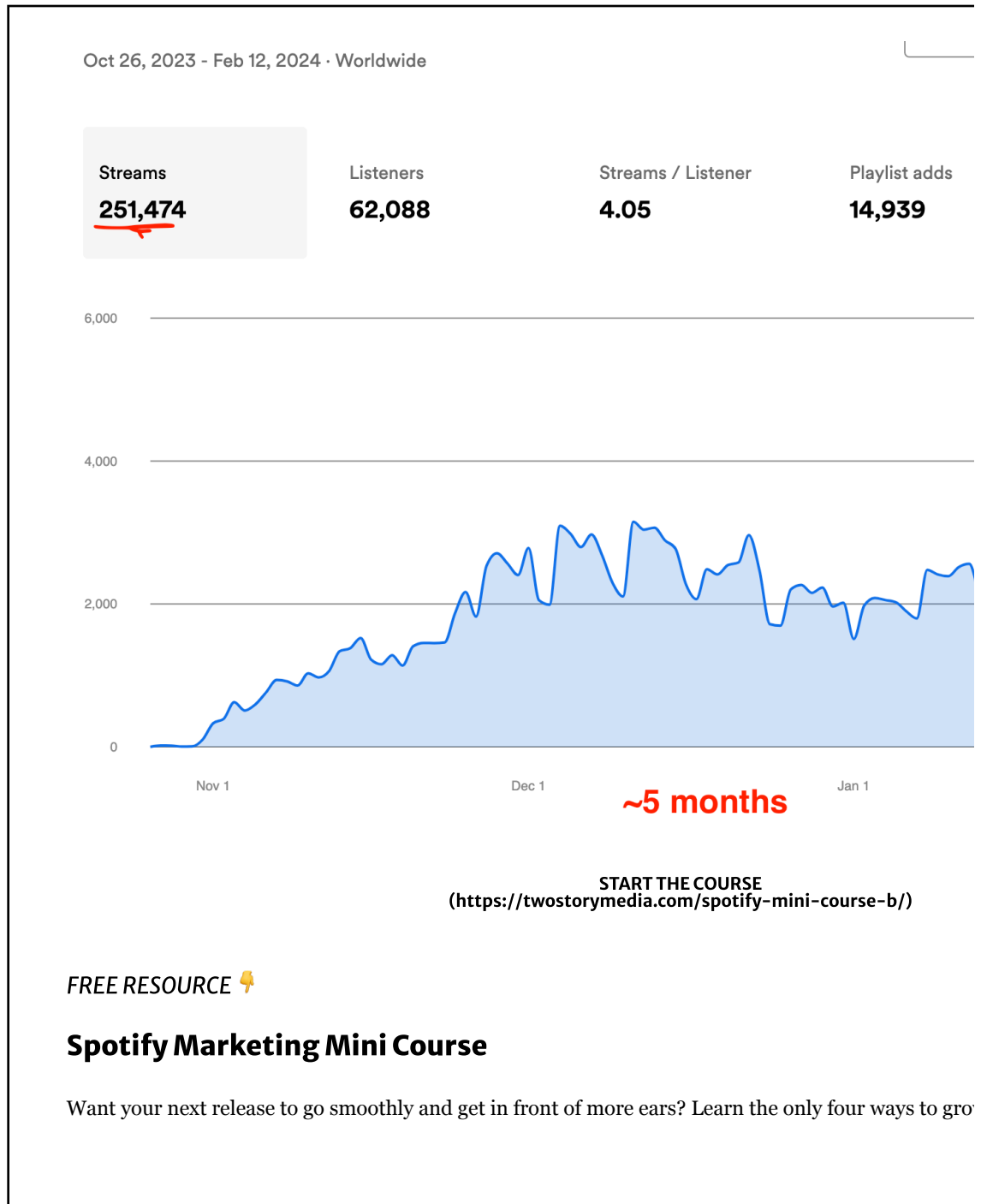
There’s a lot more to popularity, of course.

Thompson calls it a semi-chaotic system; in other words, it’s impossible to predict with total certainty what there’s no strict formula and there’s more randomness than most of us would like to admit.

But those three and a half concepts stuck with me. Maybe they’ll stick with you, and maybe they’ll even be the journey of reaching new ears.

Don't get discouraged though, whether you achieve the name recognition of Taylor Swift or resign yourself to havin
(https://www.mashed.com/151765/we-finally-understand-why-starbucks-always-spells-your-name-wrong
(https://twostorymelody.com/)) of your life, your melody still matters.

Keep making it, and good luck.



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JON ANDERSON (<https://twostorymelody.com>)

Two truths and a lie: Jon loves understanding how songs are made. Jon once attempted to swim across the Pacific Ocean, but only made it to Hawaii. Jon was the stunt double for Sandra Bullock in the films *Gravity* and *The Blindside*.

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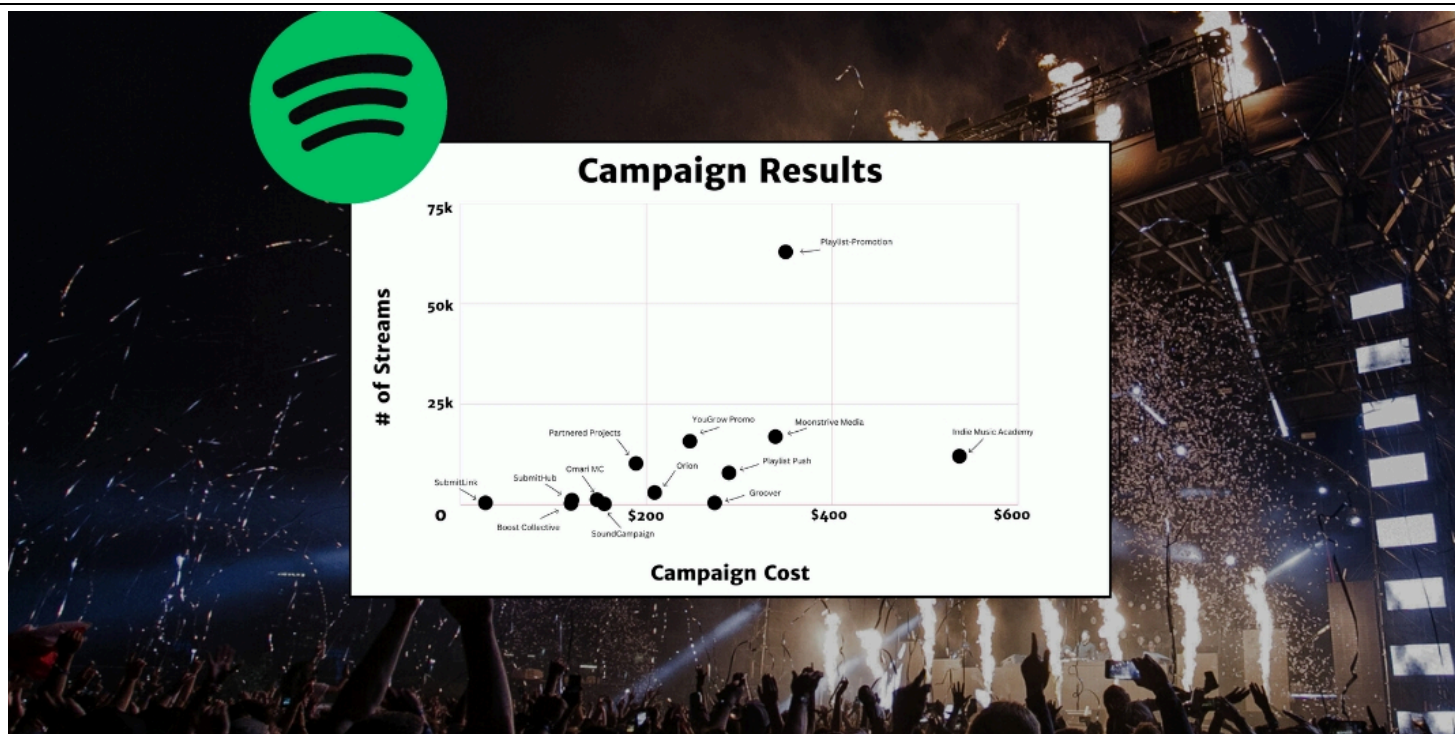
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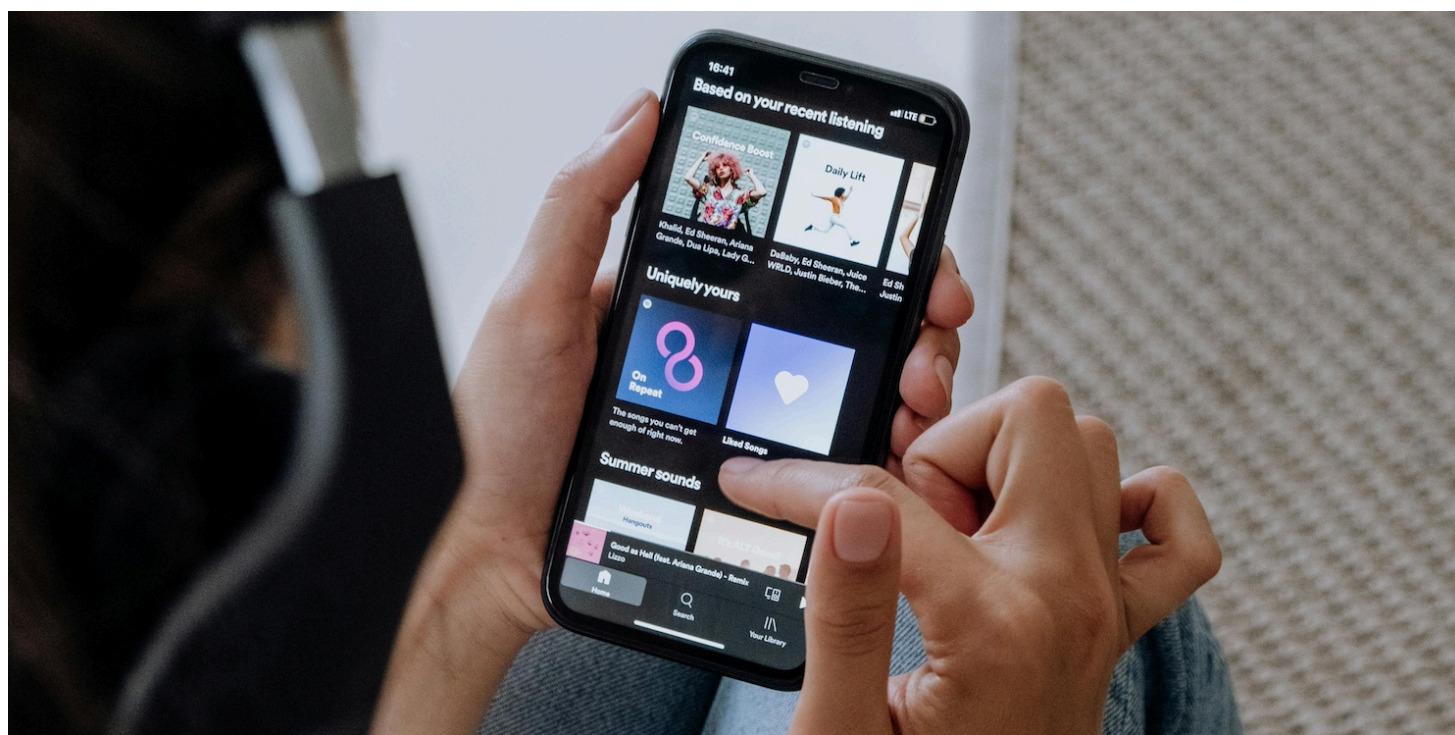
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